

Search Intent

The SERP is the answer key. Google already ran the experiment on millions of people, and it publishes the result for free.

Bottom line

Intent is what the searcher actually wants, and it is the one thing you cannot out-work. A page that answers the wrong intent has a hard ceiling no amount of backlinks or word count will lift. The good news is that you never have to guess: the current top ten is Google's published answer to what satisfies that query.

Why intent beats every other input

Every other lever in SEO is incremental. You improve a title and move a few positions. You earn a link and move a few more. Intent is not incremental. It is a gate.

If somebody searches "best project management software" and you give them a page defining what project management software is, you have not written a slightly worse page. You have written a page that answers a different question. Google will rank the comparison pages above you effectively forever, because they satisfy the query and you do not.

Practitioner measurements put the cost of intent mismatch at a **35 to 40% reduction in content effectiveness** [practitioner]. In practice it behaves more like a ceiling than a percentage: mismatched pages tend not to rank at all rather than to rank slightly worse.

This is also the most common reason a genuinely good page fails. The writing is fine. The research is fine. It answers a question nobody asked in that search box.

The six intents

The classic model has four categories. In 2026 there are six, and the two additions matter.

Informational. The searcher wants to understand something. "what is technical seo", "how does indexing work". Answer with guides, explainers, definitions. Commercial pages lose here.

Navigational. The searcher wants a specific destination. "notion login", "nexuspoint contact". You only compete for your own brand terms. Chasing someone else's navigational queries is wasted effort.

Commercial investigation. The searcher is comparing before buying. "best crm for agencies", "webflow vs framer", "ahrefs alternatives". Answer with comparisons, listicles, and honest reviews. This is usually the highest-value intent for a services business, and the most under-served.

Transactional. The searcher is ready to act. "buy", "pricing", "hire", "book a demo". Answer with product, service, or pricing pages. Do not put a 3,000-word essay here.

Local. The searcher wants something nearby, whether or not they type "near me". Google infers location constantly. This needs map pack and Google Business Profile work, which is Section 35, and a blog post will not rank for it.

Generative AI intent. The newest category, and genuinely different: the searcher wants a system to *perform a task* rather than find a page. "write me a cold email", "calculate my margin", "summarize this contract". Reported at **37.5% of queries on platforms like ChatGPT** [practitioner, single source, treat as directional].

That last one has a strategic implication worth sitting with. A meaningful share of what used to be informational search has become task execution. Nobody clicks a link to have a task done for them. Some of the traffic you think you lost to AI was never going to convert anyway, and some of it is genuinely gone. Section 38 covers what to do about it.

Read the SERP, not the words

This is the method, and it is the whole section.

Do not classify intent by looking at the keyword. Classify it by searching the keyword and looking at what Google returns. The top ten is not Google's opinion. It is the outcome of an enormous, continuous experiment on real people. If comparison posts fill page one, comparison is what satisfies that query, whatever you think the words imply.

What to read off a SERP, in order:

- 1 What content type dominates?** Blog posts, product pages, comparison articles, videos, forum threads, tools. Count them. If eight of ten are listicles, a service page will not rank there.
- 2 What SERP features are present?** A featured snippet says there is a short extractable answer. A shopping pack says transactional. A map pack says local. People Also Ask shows you the adjacent questions you should also cover. An AI Overview tells you the query is being answered without a click.
- 3 How old is the top content?** Fresh dates mean a freshness system is active on this query and stale content will not hold.
- 4 Who is ranking?** Big brands only, or independent sites too? This is your realistic difficulty read, and it is better than any tool's difficulty score.
- 5 What format do the titles take?** "Best X for Y", "X vs Y", "How to X", "X pricing". The pattern is the expected answer shape.

Use an incognito window and be aware you are still seeing personalized and localized results. For anything you plan to act on, check from the location you actually target.

Mixed and ambiguous intent

Plenty of queries have no single intent. Search "crm" and you will see definitions, comparisons, and vendor homepages together. Google is hedging because searchers want different things.

Two rules:

- **A mixed SERP is an opportunity, not a problem.** Google is unsure, so a page that clearly serves one slice can take that slice.
- **Do not try to serve every intent on one page.** A page that defines the category, then compares options, then sells, tends to satisfy nobody. Split it.

One intent, one page

The working rule for 2026, which you will use constantly from Section 8 onward:

One search intent = one page = one keyword cluster.

Two of your pages targeting the same intent do not double your chances. They split your signals and compete with each other. That is **cannibalization**, and it is one of the most common self-inflicted problems on established sites. Section 8 covers how to find and fix it.

The corollary is that clusters are built by **shared SERP outcome, not by shared wording**. If two differently-worded queries return substantially the same results, they are one intent and belong on one page. If two similar-looking phrases return different results, they are two pages. The SERP decides, not the vocabulary. [practitioner]

Intent moves

Intent is not permanent. A query can shift from informational to commercial as a market matures, or acquire an AI Overview that removes the click entirely. Pages that stopped performing for no obvious reason have often had the intent change underneath them.

Practical habit: re-check the SERP for your most important queries a couple of times a year. It takes minutes and catches a class of problem that no tool will alert you to.

Why this matters

intent is the cheapest research in SEO and the most skipped. Ten minutes reading SERPs before writing saves you from producing a page that cannot rank regardless of how good it is. Every experienced SEO does this reflexively, and almost every beginner skips straight to writing.

Do this now

- 1 List 20 queries** you would want your capstone site to rank for. Real phrases a customer would type, not internal jargon.
- 2 Search each one in an incognito window** and record, in a sheet: the dominant content type, the SERP features present, whether an AI Overview appeared, and your intent classification from the six.
- 3 For each, note the shape of the top result's title.** You are collecting the expected answer format.
- 4 Flag every mismatch.** Where does your existing page answer a different intent than the SERP shows? Be honest. This is usually the most valuable output of Tier 1.
- 5 Find one pair of queries that return nearly the same results.** Those are one cluster, not two. You have just done your first clustering by SERP overlap.
- 6 Find one query where an AI Overview answers it completely.** Ask yourself whether a click was ever realistically available there.

Capstone step

You have a 20-row intent sheet for the capstone site, a list of pages whose intent is mismatched, and at least one confirmed cluster pair. This sheet becomes the spine of the keyword map you finish in Section 8. Do not lose it.

Key takeaways

- Intent is a gate, not a dial. A page answering the wrong intent has a ceiling that links and length cannot raise.
- Never classify intent from the keyword. Search it and read the SERP, which is Google's published result of a continuous experiment on real searchers.
- Six intents now: informational, navigational, commercial investigation, transactional, local, and generative AI, where the user wants a task performed rather than a page found.
- One intent, one page. Two pages chasing the same intent split your signals instead of doubling your chances. Clusters form by shared SERP outcome, not shared wording.